

Here be the fire

Agent 001 stares piracy in the face

Fact: Software companies lose crores of revenue annually to piracy, 70 per cent of the software in India is pirated—we are the eight largest consumers of pirated software. Most of us don't even care. Last week I found out why.

It was a normal day in the life of Agent 001—just saved the world from invading aliens, installed a wireless home network for my grandparents and cajoled a friend to opt for an AMD solution—the evening would be quality time with my PC. Or so I thought. The phone rang. The assembly stork had just delivered a spanking new computer to my neighbourette. The lady was in distress and if there is one thing that appeals to this double-O, (apart from the Palm Zire 71) it is rescuing budding princesses from the evil clutches of technology. Where's the fire?

“Now that I have this spanking beige blinding my senses, how can I use it to best extract all the Rs 20,000 that I sunk into it?” asks the lady, pointing out the fire. “Software, madam is the antidote to all your problems, stuff it with office suites, anti-virus solutions, firewalls, image editors and games; and pretty soon, you will have fun and productivity ringing through these pink walls.” My suave best, a pseudo-American accent duly attached, to further enhance the air of superiority and foreknowledge of all things digital. She asked prices. Of all the things she could have asked about, she had to ask about prices! “Windows XP

Professional Rs 9,900, Office XP Professional Rs 18,500, Macro...”, you had to hear the screams! Hell indeed hath no fury like thus displayed. “How can software, something that comes on a plastic-ka CD cost so much? This is daylight robbery! Insanity!” Hands flayed with murderous intent, lips uttered words that dare not appear in print. The world reeled.

Run Agent run

If software be the new religion, piracy is the taboo that everyone loves to indulge in. Everyone. Given the asking price of most software, there is little left to debate, but morality. The latest Windows OS costs upwards of Rs 7,000; Microsoft's Office suite upwards of Rs 15,500 and may the angels send you a cheque if you work with a 3D publishing tool—Rs 1,45,000 for 3D Studio MAX!

A brisk walk to the nearest market, and illegal copies of games and productivity applications abound with naked excess. Burned using the fastest CD-Writers (Rs 3,000 and falling) on the cheapest CD media (Rs 10 and falling), adorned with the flimsiest covers (photo-copied at 10 paisa, thank you very much) and displayed on make-shift shacks that can disappear faster than a magicians' rabbit; voila—Rs 80 for the *laatesh maal!*



ILLUSTRATION: Mahesh Benkar

made and the suppliers come around on a monthly basis asking around for new orders. They take back the unsold CDs and replace them with newer versions.

The market is just one source of such warez: your friend, your colleague, your neighbour... with the Internet pinging every home, all you need is bandwidth and peer-to-peer software to get your hands dirty. The thing is, most of us are unaware of the wrongs attached to piracy. It is tantamount to stealing, you are supposed to pay for it, so cough up and put up. Those who can afford to cough, do it. Those who can't, shrug and pirate.

If morality be the bone of contention in your kebab, then open-source software offers a handy toothpick. You can get a Linux distribution, for example, for a little over Rs 3,000. A distribution packed with all and sundry: office suites, games, image editors, MP3 players, you name it, it got it. Linux is young for the desktop—teething and crying, it grows everyday—but is unlikely to be able to run your favourite game or the application you are most familiar with.

What India needs is affordable software. Is anyone listening?

A Hole in your Pocket		
	Licensed Copies	Pirated Price
Windows XP Professional OEM	Rs 6,900	Rs 80
Windows XP Professional Full	Rs 9,900	Rs 80
Office XP Standard	Rs 15,500	Rs 80
Office XP Professional	Rs 18,500	Rs 80
Macromedia Flash	Rs 19,900	Rs 80
Director 8.5	Rs 43,500	Rs 80
Tally 6.3 Single-User	Rs 18,500	Rs 80
Tally 6.3 Multi-User	Rs 37,000	Rs 80
Adobe Photoshop 7	Rs 33,000	Rs 80
3D Studio MAX 5	Rs 1,45,000	Rs 80
*All prices are indicative and are subject to change and may differ from region to region		